MAORI WEAPONS

Before the wars of the mid-19th century brought the Maori people into contact with firearms, the Maori's principal weapons were short clubs, long staffs, and stone-headed spears, which they used to great effect in a series of long-running tribal conflicts. Their proficiency in hand-to-hand fighting can be traced to the ancient martial art of *Mau Rakau*, meaning "to grasp a weapon", which was taught to all young *toa* (warriors). The Maori fighting style was entrenched in religious symbolism and ceremonies such as the *haka* (war dance), often performed holding weapons aloft.



Ceremonial club
This short wooden club appears to be a hybrid of a *wahaika* and a *maripi* (cutting tool). It features elaborate engraving depicting a bird with an elongated head that forms a beak.

Toki pou tangata
Although they favoured club-type weapons, the Maori also used the *toki*, an axe-like weapon with a horizontal blade. This *toki pou tangata* (ceremonial *toki*) is intricately carved with a jade ("greenstone") blade. Jade was a symbol of chieftainship and jade items were passed down as valuable heirlooms.